

THE HULK

The strongest man-like creature on Earth!

THE HULK

FACTFILE

REAL NAME

Robert Bruce Banner

OCCUPATION

Scientist; wanderer

BASE

Mobile

HEIGHT

7 ft

WEIGHT

1,040 lbs

EYES

Green

HAIR

Green

FIRST APPEARANCE:

Incredible Hulk #1

(May 1962)

POWERS

Fueled by gamma radiation, the Hulk possesses almost unlimited physical strength. The madder he gets, the stronger he gets. He can leap several miles in a single bound. His body heals almost instantly. He possesses a strong homing instinct for the desert where he was "born."

ALLIES/FOES

ALLIES Rick Jones, Betty Ross-Banner, Doc Samson, Jennifer Walters (She-Hulk), Jarella, the Avengers.

FOES The Leader, The Abomination, Rhino, Sandman, Juggernaut, Absorbing man, General Thaddeus "Thunderbolt" Ross, Bi-Beast, Zzzax.

ISSUE #1

In his first appearance in The Incredible Hulk #1 (May 1962), the Hulk was colored grey, rather than the more familiar green.



Bruce had a troubled childhood; his father called him a monster, and eventually killed his mother.

FIRST LOVE

The US Army recruited Banner to develop new weapons systems while he was still in high school. Bruce was placed under the authority of General Thaddeus "Thunderbolt" Ross, a blustering no-nonsense veteran. It was in the person of Ross's daughter Betty that Bruce found a kindred spirit. Both he and Betty had lost mothers, and were subjected to the outbursts of raging fathers; an attraction soon developed between them.



Recruited by the military, Bruce Banner worked on developing new weapons systems on the military base commanded by hard-nosed general "Thunderbolt" Ross.

THE GAMMA BOMB

Prodded by his military handlers, Banner developed the G-Bomb, a weapon harnessing the power of gamma radiation. On the day the bomb was to be tested, a reckless teenager, Rick Jones, drove out onto the test range on a dare, little realizing that he was standing on ground zero of the most potent explosive device ever developed. In an uncharacteristic moment of heroism, Bruce Banner rushed out onto the test site, and dragged Jones to the safety of a nearby trench before the G-Bomb detonated. However Banner was exposed to the full force of the weapon, his every atom bombarded by gamma radiation.

A child prodigy, Bruce Banner grew up in an abusive household, one that would have a profound long-term effect on his psyche. An introverted child, Bruce was ill-equipped to deal with the outbursts of his father, who called young Bruce a monster and terrorized both him and his mother. Bruce developed a multiple personality disorder, shunting aside and repressing all of his negative emotions when the trauma became too much to take. This cycle of abuse continued until the day Brian Banner slew his wife in a fit of rage. Thereafter, Bruce was shuttled from relative to relative, and grew ever more socially awkward, even as his remarkable intellect became more apparent.



Banner is bathed in gamma rays trying to save the life of Rick Jones.



Over the years, Bruce Banner's transformations into the Hulk have taken on a variety of styles. Initially, Banner would become the Hulk when the sun set, and return to his Banner identity at sunrise. Soon thereafter, Banner learned to control his transformations using a gamma ray machine, becoming a more intelligent but no less savage Hulk. Eventually, the continued exposure to gamma radiation caused Banner to transform into the Hulk whenever he became agitated or upset. Banner's Hulk persona has also differed over the years, each one apparently representing a different facet of his fragmented psyche: the childlike Green Hulk, the more intelligent but less powerful Grey Hulk, the extremely intelligent but egocentric "Professor" Hulk—and even a "Devil Hulk" representing all of the evil within Banner's soul. Additional permutations of the Hulk are apt to emerge at any given time, should conditions prove favorable.

Hulk takes on a pack of gamma-ray-infused dogs, set on him by General Ryker.



A day later, Banner was still silently screaming. But the military doctors could find nothing wrong—he had miraculously escaped the blast unscathed. Or so it seemed. For the gamma radiation Banner had been exposed to had unlocked long-repressed feelings of hate and rage. When conditions were right, Banner found himself transforming into an unstoppable juggernaut of destruction, the personification of his long-denied dark side: the incredible Hulk! At first, the Hulk only manifested at nightfall. When the sun went down, Banner would inexorably change into a green-skinned powerhouse and remain out of control until daybreak. Eventually, due in part to Banner's attempts to cure

himself of these unwanted transformations, the appearance of the Hulk would be brought on by stress and anxiety. Whenever Bruce became outraged or fearful, the change in his emotional state would trigger the gamma radiation within his system, and the Hulk would live again. For a time, with the aid of Rick Jones, Bruce kept his dual identity secret, even while the Hulk was hunted by the same military forces for whom Banner toiled. But eventually the truth was revealed to the world, forcing Banner to become a fugitive, both to escape those who desired the Hulk's destruction, and to protect those who might be harmed during his uncontrollable episodes.

MIND OF A CHILD

The character of the Hulk changed over time. Initially, he had a strong dislike for humanity. However he mellowed as the years went by, resulting in a more childlike Hulk. He simply wanted to be left



MULTIPLE PERSONALITIES

- 1 Bruce Banner
- 2 Savage Hulk
- 3 Joe Fixit
- 4 Mindless Hulk
- 5 Professor Hulk

alone, and couldn't understand why people were persecuting him. Eventually, the super-powered psychiatrist Doc SAMSON figured out the truth: each of the Hulk's personalities represented a different fragment of Banner's shattered psyche. For a time, Samson was able to fuse the disparate elements of Banner's mind together, granting Banner the strength of the Hulk while allowing him to maintain his own intellect. But this construct proved unstable, and eventually splintered once again.

Over the years, the Hulk has proved a force for good almost as often as he has been an engine of destruction. He was instrumental in the formation of the AVENGERS, Earth's Mightiest Heroes, though friction between himself and his teammates quickly led to him leaving the group. He has stood side-by-side with the DEFENDERS, DOCTOR STRANGE, the SUB-MARINER, and the SILVER SURFER in defense of our planet. But for the most part, the Hulk calls no man friend. Bruce Banner and his superhuman alter ego remain ever at odds, as they strive to stay one step ahead of forces who would see the Hulk destroyed, or exploit his power for their own ends. **TB**

ESSENTIAL STORYLINES

- **Incredible Hulk #312** The truth about Bruce Banner's multiple personality disorder and traumatic childhood is revealed.
- **Incredible Hulk #377** Doc Samson unites Banner's splintered psyche into an intelligent Hulk.
- **Incredible Hulk #24-25** General "Thunderbolt" Ross unleashes the Hulk against the Abomination, who had secretly poisoned Ross's daughter and Hulk's beloved, Betty Banner!

